

The Art of Tactics

UEFA Technical Director Andy Roxburgh talks diamonds, lemons, attack, defense, Rooney and Ronaldo as he ponders a revolutionary new formation. This article first appeared in the 2005 December/January issue of the official magazine of the UEFA Champions League. Although this article discusses the European Championship of 2004, it is applicable to today – see Jeff Tipping's article on the counterattack.

Editor's note: Many of the statements in this article are set in the context of the time, which was only months after Greece made an historic run to claim the title at Euro 2004. Comments regarding individual players (such as Deco, Wayne Rooney, etc.) should be referred to as the players were at the time, not as they are now (In 2004 Rooney had only just burst onto the international scene).

Andy Roxburgh, UEFA's technical director, looks worried.

"People reading this will think we're mad," he says, staring out of his office window at the waters of Lake Geneva.

We have been discussing some very unusual tactics. It is Friday afternoon at UEFA's Nyon headquarters. The offices dip in the middle, so passing motorists still can enjoy their view of the lake. It will remind British visitors of a certain age of Tracy Island, the secret lair for International Rescue in Thunderbirds. Roxburgh has just returned from a conference of Europe's national team coaches in Stockholm.

We had been talking about soccer for more than an hour. Roxburgh is dispensing wisdom on subjects as diverse as the significance of the Greek victory at Euro 2004, Deco's goal for Barcelona against Celtic ("if you're going to lose, you're better off losing to a goal like that, although obviously Celtic fans might disagree") and complexities of the new offside law when I asked him the question I had always wanted to ask someone with his tactical acumen and experience in the game: Whatever happened to total soccer?

He answered, initially, by placing total soccer in context. "It was a different game then. You had to have the coach and the players with the quality and the courage to take the responsibility – and you had to risk losing. But the Dutch didn't like to win ugly. Cruyff always said style was more important than winning, and they still believe they won in a sense—even though they lost the World Cup final, they really believe that."

A NEW FORMATION: 4-6-0

At the time, total soccer was hailed as revolutionary. Thirty years later, it seems more like a passing fad. Will it ever come back? After all,

even Ajax doesn't play it now, does it?

"Not really," says Roxburgh. "But it's funny, the other day I was talking to Carlos Alberto Parreira (Brazil's coach at the time) and I asked him how he was getting on with his 4-6-0 formation."

Sorry, 4-6-0? "Yes, 4-6-0. He mentioned it a few years ago, said he was trying to work out a way you could play 4-6-0. You'd have four defenders at the back, although even they'd be allowed to run forward, and six players in midfield, all of whom could rotate, attack and defend. It's total soccer in a way. I was asking him about it the other day on the phone, laughing about it."

But could anybody, even Brazil, play 4-6-0? Roxburgh gives a short laugh. "Well, this is Brazil: They did just win the Copa America with their reserve team. But you'd need to have six Decos in midfield – he doesn't just attack, he runs, tackles, covers, all over the pitch; you find him playing at right back sometimes. And they'd need to coordinate their runs and their movement." He gives a quick shake of the head as he contemplates all the variables involved.

A SHORT COURSE IN GREEK MYTHOLOGY

Otto Rehhagel's Greece won Euro 2004 playing a less exalted 1-3-5-1 in defense and 1-3-3-3 in attack. Is Greece's formation a more reliable index of where tactics are going than 4-6-0?

"Not necessarily," says the UEFA technical director. "Fifteen out of the 16 teams at Euro 2004 played a flat back four with zonal marking, but the only one that didn't, using a libero and markers, won the competition. Otto Rehhagel won because he posed a problem people had forgotten how to solve. It wasn't fashionable, but it was effective soccer. Some ideas are ageless."

"Especially in the knockout games, they controlled the matches without having control of the ball, which isn't easy to do. When they went 1-0 up against France and Portugal, you couldn't see the other side scoring. There was a point, in the final, where Theo Zagorakis just lifted the ball over two Portuguese players, Nuno Valente and Jorge Andrade. It was Figo-esque, his way of saying 'We are in control.'"

Roxburgh says Rehhagel's system was no happy accident. "Otto's view was, why should he try a watered-down version of someone else's system? As a coach, it can be best to go with what you know, and he used a system that he knew inside out as a player and a coach. And whatever you say about his system, you have to admit that Greece got the ball into attack very quickly when they had possession."

Greece's goals had a certain old-fashioned simplicity about them: two headers from corners and a header from a cross disposed of Portugal, the Czech Republic and France. Why, I ask, does he think France, in particular, looked so listless against the Greeks?

"They needed to get the ball to Thierry Henry faster. Henry is at his most dangerous running in the center from the left or running just left of center. Against Greece, he drifted too wide because he wasn't getting any space. That's one of the things you want to do—push a threat to the touchline. Greece's opponents weren't used to being marked so tightly. The old method turned out to be a novelty."

DIAMONDS AND LEMONS

Roxburgh knows that Rehhagel's style of play didn't always endear him to neutrals, but insists that, as a professional, it's hard to question the quality of his work. Did you know, for example, that Greece defended 51 corners in six games at Euro 2004 – and didn't concede a single goal from them?

"Marcello Lippi (coach of the Italian National Team) has a saying for what good coaches do – he calls it 'squeezing the lemon', maximizing the resources you have, and there was nobody better at it in Euro 2004 than Otto: Even Felipe Scolari said so. It's not just the way the team played, it's the man-management, the number of times he met his players one-on-one for a cup of coffee to talk them through it."

So are man-markers and defensive barriers the way ahead? "Not necessarily. People have had time to look over the tapes now; they may have found an answer. But the problem of the defensive block – and how to overcome it – is something all coaches have to face, not just the national coaches, but in the UEFA Champions League, too."

"It's easy to put two blocks down: one in defense and one in midfield. Sometimes, teams will put a midfield screen of two in front of the back four. Sometimes in the diamond formation in a 4-4-2, you'll have a one-man screen: You need to have very good defenders to get away with that."

"As a coach, you have to decide how you're going to get around this block. Playing through it can be very frustrating, as Arsenal found against Inter at Highbury last season. If you're trying to play through the middle, you'll commit more players and be more vulnerable when the move breaks down."

"You can rely on the long ball, collective attack, or, if you've got the players, the solo run. They can distort the shape of a defense, but you need the mental strength and

self-belief to cope with the fact that many of these runs are going to fail. Thierry Henry is a master of the counterattacking solo run.”

As, I say, is Wayne Rooney. Roxburgh, for one, thinks the Ronaldo runs have a point. “He reminds me of (Brazilian) Ronaldo. He has great pace, acceleration, but he has this quality that Ronaldo has: He has amazing deceleration. You watch when he’s through on goal, he slows right down and makes the goalkeeper make the call and then, as soon as he’s got a clue from the keeper, he’ll go the other way.”

The brilliance of individuals is, you sense, what Roxburgh likes to talk about most; a legacy, perhaps, from his own playing days as a striker in the Scottish league. He still is remembered fondly in Falkirk, being a member of the 11 that fans recently voted as their best team of all time, the free-scoring side of 1969-70 that took the Bairns into the top flight.

As a coach, he had different priorities. As Scotland manager he once had to figure out a way to stop a genius like Gheorghe Hagi (“We noticed that he liked to play in a particular space and we just squeezed his space”), but he is still a firm believer in the ability of the type of players he calls “free spirits” (Zidane, Del Piero, Ballack) to turn a game, although in the long run, he emphasizes, collective endeavor is what defines truly great sides.

“Sometimes, it just comes down to a moment of individual brilliance or a mistake, but teams who rely on slow, patient build-ups will struggle to break down those blocks.”

THE LONG BALL GAME

“You are seeing more wide play because you’ve got to find space somewhere, and it can be less congested on the wings,” he says. “I don’t necessarily mean the old-style winger: sometimes it can mean launching wing-backs or midfielders into those areas. Or sometimes, as Scolari did for Portugal, a team will use a winger to take defenders and create space for teammates to follow.”

“If you can’t break down the blocks, you can shoot from distance – it worked for Rui Costa against England. Or you can try the long pass over the back. Dick Advocaat tried to bypass the block with the long ball, and Portugal did the same when they were chasing a result.”

For a nation like the Netherlands, with a genetic resistance to “winning ugly,” such a tactic was never likely to find favor with the fans, even though Gary Lineker, who played under Johan Cruyff at Barcelona, insisted his old boss wouldn’t hesitate to stick a big man up front if his side were 1-0 down with 10 minutes to go.

Roxburgh can understand why Advocaat felt obliged to experiment. But what these efforts did show was that if the long balls aren’t as accurate as a Swiss watch, they can become just an awfully quick way to concede possession. So the long ball hasn’t staged a real comeback.

COUNTERATTACK IS KING

Roxburgh is convinced that coaches are

turning to another gambit. “In the UEFA Champions League and other tournaments, you’re seeing the importance of the rapid counterattack, not with one or two players, but four or five streaming forward, the way Arsenal does.

“You need the quality of players and passes, and you need to prepare it properly in training, but you can cause a lot of problems with a group of players who go straight toward goal with pace and direct, fluid combination passing. You could go as far as to say that if you can’t counterattack, you can’t succeed.

“It’s hard to win entire tournaments with a defend-and-counter strategy, but a successful team needs to have counterattacking as part of its armory. In Euro 2004, 40 percent of the goals from open play came from counterattacks. In the Champions League, that figure is 30 percent. Manchester United, Arsenal, Dynamo Kiev, they all do it. Remember Porto in the final – making Monaco come onto them and then hitting them with the sucker punch.”

With that, his eyes light up as he recalls Barcelona’s victory at Celtic Park: “Look at the way they did it. A short pass goes wrong, Ronaldinho gets the ball, and then Deco makes the run, inviting the pass from Ronaldinho, the ball is slid over and Deco finishes – he still had some work to do from that angle.” He is, though, still enough of a Scot to note, with quiet pride, how well Celtic fought back in the second half before conceding two late goals.

“It’s all about the speed of transition. If you haven’t got the ball, it’s not about making the tackle in midfield – you don’t know where the ball is going to go. It’s all about tempting the player into the pass, stealing the pass and then it’s just like Marcello Lippi says: How much depth can you get on the ball? Can you drive it forward to the striker or the midfield player?”

Driving the ball, it turns out, is one of Roxburgh’s pet themes. “The speed of the ball has increased incredibly. Players are driving the ball at each other and the receiver has to be able to cope. I always make a point of watching warm-ups: you can learn a lot from them. I remember watching David Beckham and Roberto Carlos before a Real Madrid game, standing on either side of the pitch and driving the ball to each other.”

“It looks like fun, but they’re hitting it hard. If you’re near the pitch you can hear the noise; it’s almost a click, as they hit the ball and the other one will trap it with their foot, their knee, almost any part of the body. They’re doing it like they’re joking but they’re practicing driving through the ball. Most of the great players now are able to drive through the ball, to drive the play forward.”

OBSESSIVE POSSESSIVES

Doesn’t the risk of the counterattack make keeping the ball more crucial than ever? “Yes, but you need the right kind of possession. The idea that if you have the ball, the other side can’t score is one of the

game’s oldest axioms, but you can be obsessed with possession. Look at the way Brazil uses the ball. They pass it back, forward, sideways: they’re so comfortable in possession they can do it indefinitely. But they have what I call a rattlesnake style. They look like they’re meandering, but they’re just looking for an opportunity to strike and, as soon as they’ve found one, they make their move. But if you look at the possession statistics for Euro 2004 and the Champions League, they tell a different story.

“In Euro 2004, three teams had 57 percent possession in their games – and one of those was Germany. In last season’s Champions League, the team that kept the ball best was PSV. Look at the two finalists: Porto was only the 12th best team in possession and Monaco was the 27th-best. Deportivo had 60 percent of the ball last season away against Monaco – and lost 8-3. So it’s not just about keeping the ball; it’s how you use it. You don’t want to hit so many passes that your opponents have time to take up their formation and close down space.

“Against Manchester United, in that key game at Old Trafford, Porto had 58 percent of the possession, 14 goal attempts to the home team’s seven and successfully completed 75 percent of their passes. You can say they had a bit of luck right at the end of the game, but they earned that luck.”

What coaches now recognize, he suggests, is the need to train players not to become demoralized if they don’t have the ball. There is probably no better model for teams to emulate than Greece in Euro 2004. Only Latvia had a lower average share of possession in their games than Rehhagel’s heroes.

Porto, like Greece, was famously well-drilled and effective in defense so I wonder, does their joint reign as European champions mean the game is becoming more defensive?

“Not at all. The game goes in cycles. You have periods where the attacking game sweeps all before it and, as a reaction, you’ll have a spell when the game drifts back to the defensive arts. But in the last 10 years, soccer has become much quicker and more positive. Some of that has been driven by the public. The fans’ expectations have forced teams and coaches to play attractively.”

The casualty rate among coaches has increased at what Roxburgh considers to be an alarming rate. “When I took over the Scotland job in 1986, I was told my goal was to get the team to the World Cup in 1990 and that is what I did. I was talking to national coaches the other day and they were saying they see themselves now as almost on a two-year cycle.” There’s a last shake of the head, as if even he finds this hard to believe.

Impatience for results has sharpened the risk of club coaches being fired with enthusiasm – by bosses. “The justification for playing defensively is success. If you fail, you’re shown the door. If you play attacking soccer, you might get a stay of execution.”

With that Roxburgh is back to the pile of work on his desk. I’m left hoping that Carlos Alberto Pereira will have the guts to try out his 4-6-0 system, and the sooner the better.